

Kefan Yu

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Education **Northwestern University**, Evanston, IL *2022 - 2026 (Expected)*
B.S. Computer Science

- Research** • Evaluation and Interpretability of LLMs
- Interests** • Pragmatics of LLMs
- Natural Language Processing

Publications **Kefan Yu***, Qingcheng Zeng*, Weihao Xuan, Wanxin Li, Jingyi Wu, Rob
(*: equal contribution) Voigt, 2025, [The Pragmatic Mind of Machines: Tracing the Emergence of Pragmatic Competence in Large Language Models](#), *Preprint*

- Introduced AltPrag, a dataset based on pragmatic concept of alternatives, and provided the first systematic study of how pragmatic competence in LLMs develops across training stages (pre-training, SFT, and preference optimization).

Zihan Wang*, Kangrui Wang*, Qineng Wang*, Pingyue Zhang*, Linjie Li*, Zhengyuan Yang, Xing Jin, **Kefan Yu**, Minh Nhat Nguyen, Licheng Liu, Eli Gottlieb, Yiping Lu, Kyunghyun Cho, Jiajun Wu, Li Fei-Fei, Lijuan Wang, Yejin Choi, Manling Li, 2025, [RAGEN: Understanding Self-Evolution in LLM Agents via Multi-Turn Reinforcement Learning](#), *Preprint*

- Proposed RAGEN, a general-purpose framework for training LLM agents with multi-turn reinforcement learning, revealing key challenges in stability, rollout quality, and reasoning emergence.

Research **Toyota Technological Institute at Chicago** *June 2025 - Present*

Appointments *Research Assistant*

- Working with [Zhewei Sun](#)
- Leading an ongoing project on multilingual slang generation.

MLL-Lab, Northwestern University*Jan 2025 - Present**Intern*

- Working with [Zihan Wang](#) and [Manling Li](#)
- Designed and produced publication-quality figures, including the teaser figure and experimental settings.
- Conducted comprehensive experimental evaluation for the RAGEN framework.

LingMechLab, Northwestern University*Feb 2024 - Present**Research Assistant*

- Working with [Qingcheng Zeng](#) and [Rob Voigt](#)
- Executed data preprocessing protocols and performed dataset annotation to support research initiatives.
- Led the development of the AltPrag paper, including dataset creation, experiments, figures, and writing contributions.

Teaching**CS336: Design & Analysis of Algorithms***Spring 2025**Peer Mentor***CS449: Deep Learning***Winter 2024**Peer Mentor***Industry****CDK Global, Hoffman Estates, IL***June 2024 – Aug 2024***Experience***Software Engineer Intern***Skills****Tools & Packages***Python, Linux, Conda, Jupyter, Git, Pytorch, Numpy, Huggingface***Language***Mandarin (native), English (proficient), Japanese (intermediate)*